

Be healthy to spend on healthcare

With budget **around the corner**, and Viksit India on **the hive mind**, health spend should be top priority for the state. It isn't. In 2024, **Gol**, **in collaboration with** states, **assessed** India's 2 lakh public healthcare facilities under the National Health Mission (NHM). Nearly 80% were found to fail to **meet** minimum essential standards for infra, **manpower** and equipment. In such a situation, one would expect the Indian state to **pump** more money **into** the health sector - and its citizens to demand it. However, despite repeated recommendations from National Health Policy 2017, Economic Surveys (2021, 2022-23), and the 15th Finance Commission to raise government health expenditure to at least 2.5% of GDP, the 2024-25 health budget remains **stagnant** at 1.9%. South Africa **allocates** 4.3%, Brazil 4%, and China over 3%.

According to Indian Public Health Standards, each primary healthcare centre should **cater to** 20k-30k people. Instead, the figure often exceeds 36,000 as of 2020-21. **Community health centres**, meant to provide specialised services, **are** in even worse condition. The system's **bias** towards **curative** healthcare - with **preventive** healthcare receiving just 14% of government funds - **results in** long-term **inefficiencies** and **soaring** healthcare costs.



Budget '25 must prioritise preventive healthcare, including awareness campaigns on issues like **anaemia**, diabetes and **cardiovascular** conditions, along with health **screenings** and **wellness** programmes. With medical **inflation** at 14% - the highest in Asia - there are **justified** calls to raise Section 80D deduction of I-T Act and **exempt** health insurance premiums from 18% GST. **Becoming** a viksit nation **is inextricably** linked to the health of its citizens and their access to healthcare. Anything less is **daydreaming**.

[Practice Exercise]

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

Vocabulary

1. **Around the corner** (phrase) – Approaching, imminent, near at hand, coming soon निकट भविष्य में
2. **The hive mind** (noun) – the opinions or thoughts of a group of people, especially internet users, considered together. दल के रूप में मिलकर काम करना
3. **In collaboration with** (phrase) – Working together with, in partnership with, jointly, cooperatively साथ मिलकर
4. **Assess** (verb) – Evaluate, appraise, judge, estimate मूल्यांकन करना
5. **Meet** (verb) – Fulfill, satisfy, comply with, adhere to पूरा करना
6. **Manpower** (noun) – the people that you need to do a particular job श्रमशक्ति
7. **Pump** (verb) – invest a large amount of money in something. निवेश करना
8. **Stagnant** (adjective) – Not growing, static, unchanged, motionless स्थिर/रूका हुआ
9. **Allocate** (verb) – Distribute, assign, allot, earmark आवंटित करना
10. **Cater** (to) (verb) – Serve, provide for, supply, address ज़रूरत पूरी करना
11. **Bias** (noun) – Prejudice, partiality, predisposition, inclination पक्षपात
12. **Curative** (adjective) – Healing, remedial, therapeutic, corrective उपचारात्मक
13. **Preventive** (adjective) – Proactive, protective, precautionary, preemptive रोकथाम संबंधी
14. **Result in** (phrasal verb) – Lead to, cause, bring about, end in कारण होना
15. **Inefficiency** (noun) – Ineffectiveness, inadequacy, lack of productivity, wastefulness अक्षमता
16. **Soaring** (adjective) – Rising rapidly, escalating, increasing steeply, surging तेज़ी से बढ़ता हुआ
17. **Anaemia** (noun) – a condition in which the body does not have enough healthy red blood cells खून की कमी
18. **Cardiovascular** (adjective) – Relating to the heart and blood vessels हृदय और रक्तवाहिकाओं से संबंधित
19. **Screening** (noun) – Examination, testing, evaluation, check-up जांच/स्क्रीनिंग
20. **Wellness** (noun) – Good health, well-being, fitness, soundness कल्याण

21. **Inflation** (noun) – Rise in prices, increase in cost of living, economic inflation
महंगाई

22. **Justified** (adjective) – Warranted, reasonable, defensible, legitimate उचित

23. **Exempt** (verb) – Free from obligation, excuse, release, absolve मुक्त करना

24. **Inextricably** (adverb) – Indivisibly, inseparably, indissolubly, inevitably
अभिन्न रूप से

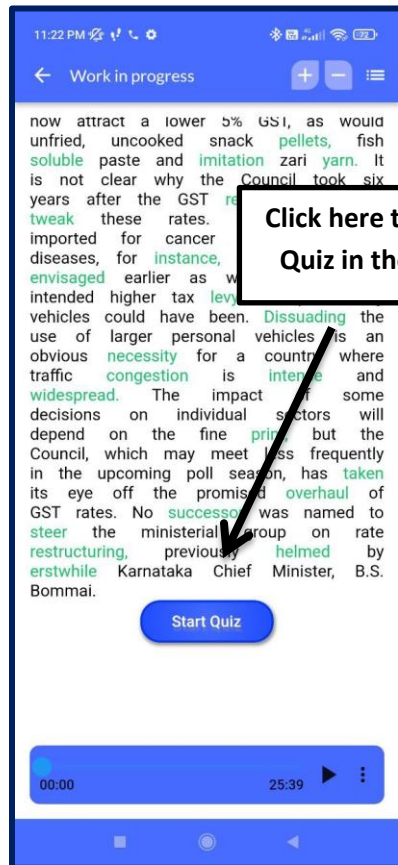
25. **Daydream** (verb) – Fantasize, imagine, muse, be lost in thought सपना देखना

@mocks_wallah

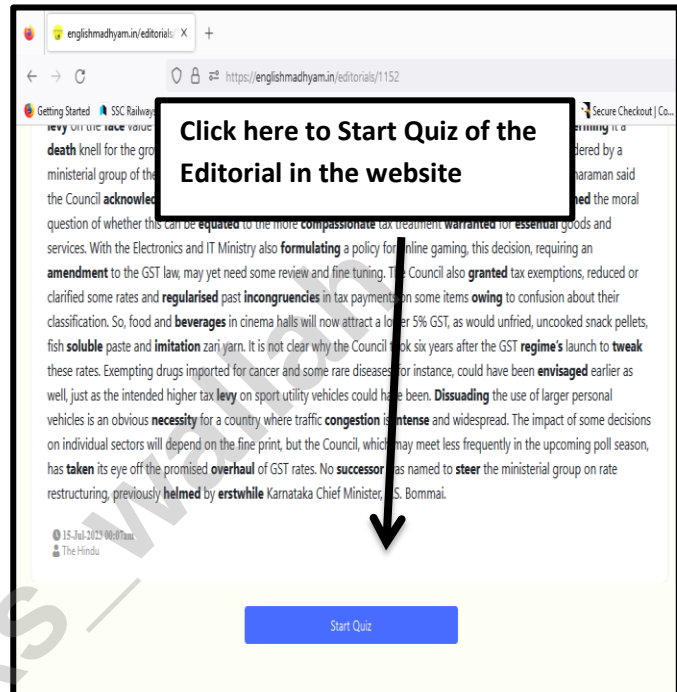
Summary of the Editorial

1. **Healthcare Spending Deficit:** Despite the critical role of health in a "Viksit India," India's healthcare spending remains stagnant at 1.9% of GDP, far below global peers like South Africa (4.3%), Brazil (4%), and China (3%).
2. **Inadequate Public Healthcare Facilities:** A 2024 government assessment revealed that nearly 80% of the 2 lakh public healthcare facilities failed to meet minimum standards for infrastructure, manpower, and equipment.
3. **Overburdened Healthcare System:** Primary healthcare centres (PHCs) cater to over 36,000 people instead of the recommended 20,000–30,000, and community health centres are even worse off.
4. **Curative vs. Preventive Bias:** Only 14% of government health funds are allocated to preventive healthcare, leading to inefficiencies and rising long-term costs.
5. **Medical Inflation Crisis:** India faces the highest medical inflation in Asia at 14%, further straining the affordability of healthcare for citizens.
6. **Need for Increased Allocation:** The National Health Policy (2017), Economic Surveys, and Finance Commission have recommended raising health expenditure to at least 2.5% of GDP, which remains unfulfilled.
7. **Focus on Preventive Healthcare:** Budget 2025 should prioritize preventive measures such as health screenings, wellness programs, and awareness campaigns for diseases like anaemia, diabetes, and cardiovascular conditions.
8. **Tax Reforms for Health Expenses:** Calls are growing to raise Section 80D deduction limits under the Income Tax Act and exempt health insurance premiums from the current 18% GST.
9. **Healthcare Accessibility as a Benchmark for Development:** Becoming a developed nation is directly tied to improving citizens' health and ensuring equitable access to quality healthcare services.
10. **The Path to a Viksit Bharat:** Significant investment in healthcare is essential for a robust workforce, reduced out-of-pocket expenses, and the overall well-being of the population. Anything less undermines the vision of a developed India.

Practice Exercise: Banking Pattern Based



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